

CANADA, HISTORY OF



FOR MOST OF ITS history, Canada has been home to Native Americans and Inuits. They were descendants of the first people to settle there during the Ice Age, and built advanced cultures based on hunting and trapping fish and animals. In 1497, the first Europeans visited the country, establishing settlements in the early 1600s. In the 18th century, French and British armies fought for control of the entire country. The British won, but a sizeable French community has remained in Québec to this day.

Fur trading

European settlers were attracted to Canada by the wealth to be made from furs and skins of animals trapped in the forests. The English-owned Hudson's Bay Company, established in 1670, and other trading companies set up fortified trading posts to trade furs and other goods with local Indian tribes. Québec (established 1608) and Montreal (1642) became important centres of the fur trade.



First Canadians

The first inhabitants of Canada were peoples from northern Asia who crossed a land bridge from Siberia and moved south through America more than 20,000 years ago. The Inuits lived in the Arctic regions, while other Native American peoples occupied the plains and coastal areas. They all developed their own distinctive cultures. For example, the tribes of the northwest coast recorded their family history on totem poles, carving out representations of the family spirits on the trunks of cedar trees.

Jacques Cartier

The French sea captain Jacques Cartier (1491–1557) was hired by Francis I of France, to look for a northwest passage to China round the north of America. In 1534, he sailed into the Gulf of St Lawrence, and, in 1535, discovered the St Lawrence River. As he sailed up the river, he stopped at two Indian villages – Stadacona (modern Québec) and Hochelaga (Montreal). As a result, French immigrants began to settle by the St Lawrence River.



Capture of Québec

In 1759, British forces led by General James Wolfe attacked Québec, capital of the French colony of New France. Wolfe captured the city arriving from the Gulf of St. Lawrence with a flotilla of 168 ships that carried over 30,000 men. However, both he and the French commander, Louis, Marquis de Montcalm, were killed. All of French North America came under British control.



Wolfe's flotilla arrives in Québec.



Independence

In 1867, Canada became an independent dominion (nation) within the British Empire. At first, the new country consisted only of parts of Ontario, Quebec, and two provinces on the Atlantic coast. Gradually, the other provinces joined. By 1905, most of Canada had joined the Dominion.

Immigration

At the end of the 19th century, Canada's economy expanded and two transcontinental railways improved communications. Canada became an attractive place for European emigrants, and between 1891 and 1914, over three million people came to Canada in search of work and a new life. Canada's government encouraged Europeans to emigrate, promising future citizens health and wealth in their new home.



Canadian government poster

Timeline

1497 John Cabot, an Italian sailor, claims Newfoundland for Britain.

1534–35 Jacques Cartier explores the Gulf of St. Lawrence for France; then discovers the St. Lawrence River.

1605 French establish the first European colony at Port Royal, Nova Scotia.

1754 French and Indian War between Britain and France. France forced to relinquish Québec to Britain.

1846 Oregon Treaty confirms present borders with USA

1949 Founder member of NATO

1968 Québec Party formed to demand independence for Québec.

1989 UK transfers all power relating to Canada in British law.

1998 Government apologises to Native Americans over land.



Canadian flag



Québec

Canada recognized both its English- and French-speakers as equal, but in the 1960s, many people in French-speaking Québec began to press for their province to become independent. In 1982, Québec was given the status of a "distinct society", but referendums seeking independence were defeated in 1980 and 1995.

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